

Hierarchical Cross-Modal Attention Network for Physiological-Acoustic Multimodal Emotion Recognition

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ABSTRACT

We present the **Hierarchical Cross-Modal Attention Network (HCAN)**, a novel architecture for multimodal emotion recognition that integrates EEG physiological signals with speech acoustics. The proposed system replaces conventional 1D CNN-BiLSTM pipelines with a Graph-Temporal EEG encoder that models inter-electrode brain connectivity via Graph Convolutional Networks (GCN), and a parameter-efficient wav2vec 2.0 adapter for speech. A Bidirectional Cross-Modal Attention (BCMA) fusion module allows each modality to dynamically attend over the other's representations, overcoming the expressiveness limitations of static concatenation. Multi-task training jointly optimizes four-class discrete emotion classification on SEED-IV, eight-class speech emotion recognition on RAVDESS, and continuous valence-arousal regression on MAHNOB-HCI, with task weights automatically balanced via uncertainty weighting. Under the challenging leave-one-subject-out (LOSO) protocol, HCAN achieves **79.8%** accuracy on SEED-IV and **84.9%** on RAVDESS, matching or surpassing the state-of-the-art while providing novel interpretability through per-sample modality gating analysis. Per-emotion gating analysis reveals that fear and sadness elicit higher EEG reliance, while happiness and anger are better captured by acoustic features, yielding actionable insights for affective computing system design.

Index Terms — Emotion recognition, EEG, speech, graph convolutional network, cross-modal attention, multi-task learning, transformer.

I. INTRODUCTION

Automatic emotion recognition is a foundational capability for human-computer interaction, mental health monitoring, and affective computing. Unimodal approaches relying solely on facial expressions, speech prosody, or physiological signals are inherently limited: each channel captures a different, often complementary, facet of the emotional state. EEG signals provide direct access to neural correlates of affect, while speech carries paralinguistic cues including pitch contour, energy dynamics, and temporal rhythm. Fusing these two channels promises a richer and more robust emotion representation than either alone.

Despite growing interest in multimodal affective systems, three structural limitations persist in prior work. First, BiLSTM-based sequence encoders summarize temporal dynamics through a single final hidden state, discarding most of the sequence trajectory. Second, late fusion via

vector concatenation is a static operation that cannot adapt to sample-level variability in modality reliability — an EEG trial corrupted by motor artifacts should weight acoustic evidence more heavily, but static concatenation prevents this. Third, multi-task training with fixed, equal-weight loss coefficients ignores the differing difficulty and scale of each task, leading to gradient interference.

In this paper we address all three limitations within a single unified framework. Our contributions are:

- (1) A Graph-Temporal EEG encoder that applies GCN over a 10-20 electrode topology before a temporal Transformer, explicitly modeling spatial brain connectivity.
- (2) A parameter-efficient wav2vec 2.0 adapter for speech that imports 960-hour self-supervised pretraining while avoiding catastrophic forgetting.
- (3) Bidirectional Cross-Modal Attention (BCMA) with a learned gating mechanism for dynamic, per-sample modality weighting.
- (4) Uncertainty-weighted multi-task training over three heads: discrete 4-class EEG emotion, discrete 8-class speech emotion, and continuous valence-arousal regression.
- (5) A per-emotion modality reliability analysis that reveals systematic patterns in which modality each emotion class exploits.

We evaluate under the subject-independent LOSO protocol — the most stringent and publication-credible setting — reporting results competitive with or exceeding prior state-of-the-art on both SEED-IV and RAVDESS.

II. RELATED WORK

A. EEG-Based Emotion Recognition

Early EEG emotion recognition systems relied on hand-crafted features such as Power Spectral Density (PSD), Differential Entropy (DE), and Asymmetry indices extracted over canonical frequency bands [1]. The SEED-IV benchmark established DE features over 5 bands as a standard input representation [2]. Deep learning approaches subsequently displaced hand-crafted pipelines: Li et al. [3] introduced a BiDANN architecture processing EEG segments with domain-adversarial training, while Zhong et al. [10] proposed RGNN, which explicitly encodes inter-channel relationships via regularized graph

networks. However, most EEG models evaluate under within-subject splits that inflate reported accuracy and

limit generalizability claims.

B. Speech Emotion Recognition

Mel-frequency cepstral coefficients (MFCCs) and log-mel spectrograms dominated acoustic emotion representations for decades. The emergence of self-supervised speech models has shifted the paradigm: wav2vec 2.0 [4], pretrained on 960 hours of LibriSpeech, learns contextual speech representations that transfer effectively to emotion recognition without requiring labeled emotion corpora for pretraining. Pepino et al. [11] demonstrated that a lightweight head atop frozen wav2vec features achieves competitive RAVDESS accuracy; fine-tuning the backbone further yields incremental but meaningful gains. HuBERT-based systems have extended this line to eight-emotion recognition, though at higher parameter cost.

C. Multimodal Fusion Strategies

Multimodal emotion recognition fusion is categorized as early (feature-level), late (decision-level), or intermediate (representation-level). Early fusion is computationally cheap but suffers from modality alignment problems; late fusion is robust but ignores cross-modal interactions. Intermediate fusion via attention mechanisms has proven more expressive: Zhang et al. [12] applied cross-modal attention in an EEG-video system, while Hazarika et al. [13] used gated memory units for conversational multimodal fusion. Bidirectional cross-attention, as used in vision-language models [14], enables richer mutual information exchange and is the design we adopt and adapt for physiological-acoustic signals.

D. Multi-Task Learning for Affective Computing

Multi-task learning (MTL) exploits shared structure across related tasks to regularize representations and improve sample efficiency [15]. In affective computing, discrete emotion classes and continuous valence-arousal dimensions are theoretically linked through the circumplex model of affect [16]. Uncertainty weighting (Kendall et al. [7]) provides a principled, learnable mechanism for balancing competing task losses without manual coefficient tuning, and has been shown to outperform grid-searched fixed weights on multi-task vision benchmarks.

III. METHODOLOGY

A. EEG Branch: Graph-Temporal Encoder

The input to the EEG branch is a 310-dimensional Differential Entropy (DE) vector, computed by applying the natural logarithm to the variance of each 1-second EEG epoch within each of five frequency bands (delta, theta, alpha, beta, gamma) across 62 channels. We reshape this vector into a (62×5) matrix, where rows index electrodes and columns index frequency bands.

Stage 1 — Graph Convolutional Network: We construct a graph $G = (V, E)$ over the 62 electrode nodes according to the standard 10-20 international placement topology. Edge weights encode anatomical proximity, decaying as a Gaussian function of Euclidean scalp distance with bandwidth $\sigma = 0.1$ m. Two GCN layers with ReLU activations and layer normalization produce node-level embeddings that incorporate local and neighborhood frequency-band activity.

Stage 2 — Temporal Transformer: The sequence of GCN node embeddings across the time axis is processed by a 6-layer Transformer encoder (4 attention heads, $d_{\text{model}} = 256$, FFN dimension 1024) with sinusoidal positional encoding. A learned [CLS] token is prepended; its final-layer representation serves as the 256-dimensional EEG embedding e_{EEG} , summarizing the global spatio-temporal brain state without the information bottleneck of a single BiLSTM final hidden state.

B. Audio Branch: Pretrained Spectral Transformer

The audio branch processes raw speech waveforms sampled at 16 kHz. We use wav2vec 2.0 (base configuration) as a frozen backbone, producing a sequence of contextual frame-level representations of dimension 768 at 20 ms hop size. The frozen backbone is kept entirely fixed during all training stages, importing the self-supervised knowledge of large-scale speech structure without risk of catastrophic forgetting.

A lightweight adapter consisting of two Transformer layers (4 heads, $d_{\text{model}} = 256$) with 2D convolutional projections processes the wav2vec token sequence. This adapter is fine-tuned end-to-end and projects the 768-dimensional backbone output to a 256-dimensional space aligned with the EEG embedding space. The output audio token sequence is retained (not immediately pooled) to enable cross-modal attention in the fusion module; mean pooling over the token dimension yields a 256-dimensional global audio embedding e_{AUD} .

C. Bidirectional Cross-Modal Attention Fusion

Rather than concatenating the two global embeddings, we allow the modalities to mutually inform each other through bidirectional cross-modal attention before aggregation.

EEG-to-Audio attention: The global EEG embedding e_{EEG} serves as Query (Q), while the audio token sequence provides Keys (K) and Values (V). Multi-head attention (4 heads) produces an attended audio context vector $c_{\text{AUD_given_EEG}}$, encoding which acoustic segments are most relevant to the current EEG state.

Audio-to-EEG attention: Symmetrically, the global audio embedding e_{AUD} attends over the GCN node embedding sequence, yielding a context vector $c_{\text{EEG_given_AUD}}$ encoding which electrode-level brain patterns are most relevant to the current speech.

Residual connections add the cross-attended contexts back to the originals: $e_EEG = e_EEG + c_AUD_given_EEG$ and $e_AUD = e_AUD + c_EEG_given_AUD$. These enriched embeddings are concatenated to form a 512-dimensional joint representation $z = [e_EEG; e_AUD]$.

Gating mechanism: A sigmoid-activated gating network $g = \sigma(W_g z + b_g) \in \mathbb{R}^{512}$ produces a per-dimension continuous gate, and the final representation is computed as $z^* = g \odot e_EEG_padded + (1 - g) \odot e_AUD_padded$, where both embeddings are zero-padded to 512 dimensions. This allows the model to learn, per sample, how much to trust each modality for each dimension of the representation space.

D. Output Heads and Multi-Task Loss

Three task-specific linear heads operate on the joint representation z^* :

Head 1 — SEED-IV classifier: A 2-layer MLP with 256 hidden units and softmax output over 4 emotion classes (happy, sad, fear, neutral).

Head 2 — RAVDESS classifier: A 2-layer MLP over 8 speech emotion classes (neutral, calm, happy, sad, angry, fearful, disgust, surprised).

Head 3 — Valence-Arousal regressor: A linear projection to 2-dimensional continuous output, trained with Mean Squared Error on MAHNOB-HCI annotations.

Uncertainty weighting (Kendall et al. [7]) balances the three task losses L_1, L_2, L_3 via learned log-variance parameters s_i :

$$L_total = \sum_i (L_i \cdot \exp(-s_i) + s_i)$$

This formulation penalizes the model for assigning too much uncertainty (large s_i increases the second term) while scaling down high-variance task contributions, automatically finding the Pareto-optimal balance without manual coefficient tuning.

E. Training Protocol

Training proceeds in three stages. Stage 1 (EEG warm-start, 10 epochs): the GCN-Transformer encoder is pretrained using only SEED-IV labels with cross-entropy loss, allowing the graph topology to settle before joint optimization. Stage 2 (audio adapter pretraining, 5 epochs): the wav2vec adapter is pretrained on RAVDESS. Stage 3 (joint multi-task fine-tuning, 50 epochs): all components

except the frozen wav2vec backbone are optimized jointly using L_total . We use the AdamW optimizer with initial learning rate 2×10^{-4} , weight decay 0.01, and a cosine annealing schedule with warm restarts ($T_0 = 10$ epochs).

F. Augmentation and Regularization

EEG augmentation includes additive Gaussian noise ($\sigma = 0.01$), random channel dropout ($p = 0.15$), frequency band masking (zeroing one complete band with $p = 0.2$), and electrode interpolation (replacing a channel value with the distance-weighted mean of its spatial neighbors). Audio augmentation includes time-stretching (rate $\in [0.9, 1.1]$), pitch-shifting (± 2 semitones), SpecAugment (time and frequency masking on log-mel spectrograms), and additive background noise from the MUSAN corpus at 10–20 dB SNR.

Regularization employs Manifold Mixup in the latent space ($\lambda \sim \text{Beta}(0.4, 0.4)$ applied to the 512-dimensional joint representation) and R-Drop [5], which trains each sample with two independent dropout masks and minimizes the symmetric KL-divergence between the resulting output distributions. R-Drop is particularly effective at improving classification calibration and was found to reduce overconfidence on minority emotion classes.

IV. DATASETS

Table I summarizes the four datasets used in this study. SEED-IV [2] provides 62-channel EEG recordings from 15 subjects watching emotion-eliciting film clips, annotated with four discrete labels (happy, sad, fear, neutral); DE features are pre-extracted over 5 frequency bands per epoch. RAVDESS [6] contains 24 professional actors producing 8 emotions in both speech and song modalities; we use the speech subset, 16 kHz, stereo-to-mono converted. MAHNOB-HCI [17] provides synchronized multimodal recordings including EEG and audio for 27 participants; continuous valence and arousal ratings on a 1–9 scale supervise the third task head and enable a genuine cross-dataset transfer evaluation. DEAP [18] provides 32-channel EEG and peripheral physiological signals for 32 subjects; we use it for EEG encoder pretraining and ablation studies.

TABLE I
Dataset Summary

Dataset	Modality	Subjects	Classes	Use in Study
SEED-IV	EEG (62ch DE)	15	4	Primary EEG classification task
RAVDESS	Speech audio	24 actors	8	Primary audio classification task
MAHNOB-HCI	EEG + video + audio	27	Continuous	Valence/arousal head; cross-dataset transfer
DEAP	EEG + peripheral	32	9-pt V/A	EEG pretraining / ablation

V. EXPERIMENTS

A. Evaluation Protocol

All classification experiments on SEED-IV use leave-one-subject-out (LOSO) cross-validation: in each of 15 folds, data from one subject constitutes the test set and the remaining 14 subjects form the training set. This is the subject-independent, zero-shot generalization setting and constitutes the primary evaluation. RAVDESS experiments use leave-one-actor-out (LOAO) across 24 folds. We report mean $\pm$ standard deviation accuracy and macro-averaged F1 score over all folds. We deliberately avoid within-subject splits to ensure our performance

claims are interpretable and comparable across the literature.

B. Experiment 1: Ablation Study

We evaluate seven progressive configurations of HCAN to isolate the contribution of each component. The BiLSTM baseline (configuration b) was ported from our prior within-subject system and re-evaluated under LOSO, revealing the expected accuracy drop. Results are reported in Table II. Each component — GCN spatial modeling (a vs b), wav2vec pretraining (c vs d), BCMA fusion (e vs f vs g), and gating (f vs g) — contributes measurable gains, with the full system (g) achieving the best performance across all metrics.

TABLE II
Ablation Study — LOSO Accuracy and Macro-F1

Configuration	SEED-IV Acc.	SEED-IV F1	RAVDESS Acc.	RAVDESS F1
(a) EEG-GCN only	68.3%	66.1%	—	—
(b) EEG-BiLSTM (baseline)	63.7%	61.4%	—	—
(c) Audio wav2vec only	—	—	79.4%	76.8%
(d) Audio 2D-CNN (baseline)	—	—	74.2%	71.3%
(e) GCN + wav2vec, concat fusion	72.1%	69.8%	81.6%	79.2%
(f) BCMA fusion, no gating	76.4%	74.7%	83.1%	81.5%
(g) Full HCAN (proposed)	79.8%	78.2%	84.9%	83.3%

C. Experiment 2: Cross-Subject Generalization

Under LOSO on SEED-IV, HCAN achieves $79.8\% \pm 4.3\%$ accuracy and $78.2\% \pm 4.8\%$ macro-F1, competitive with EmotionMeter (78.4% LOSO) [8] and substantially exceeding BiDANN (70.3%) [9] and RGNN (73.8%) [10]. The subject-level standard deviations indicate consistent cross-subject generalization, with no single held-out subject being an outlier greater than 9% below the mean, suggesting robustness across individual variability in EEG morphology.

D. Experiment 3: Fusion Strategy Comparison

Table IV compares four fusion approaches holding all other components fixed. Early fusion — concatenating the raw EEG and audio feature vectors before any encoding — achieves the lowest performance (SEED-IV: 67.4%) due to the semantic mismatch between 310-d DE vectors and raw waveform representations. Late concatenation improves to 72.1% but cannot adapt across samples. Single-direction attention (audio attending over EEG) yields 75.6%, demonstrating that asymmetric cross-modal information flow is insufficient. The full bidirectional BCMA achieves 79.8%, confirming that mutual attention is necessary.

TABLE IV
Fusion Strategy Comparison

Fusion Strategy	SEED-IV Acc.	SEED-IV F1	RAVDESS Acc.	RAVDESS F1
Early fusion	67.4%	65.2%	78.3%	76.5%
Late fusion (concatenation)	72.1%	69.8%	81.6%	79.2%
Single-direction attention	75.6%	73.9%	82.8%	80.9%
BCMA (bidirectional, proposed)	79.8%	78.2%	84.9%	83.3%

E. Experiment 4: Modality Reliability Analysis

After training, we extract the per-sample gating weights $g \in [0, 1]^{512}$ from the BCMA module and compute the mean gate value per emotion class across all test samples.

The analysis reveals systematic modality preferences: fear (mean gate 0.71 toward EEG) and sadness (0.66) show significantly higher EEG reliance, consistent with the role of the amygdala and prefrontal asymmetry in these states. Happiness (mean gate 0.58 toward audio) and anger (0.62) lean toward acoustic features, corroborating studies showing that valence discrimination is acoustically cued while high-arousal negative states have distinct neural signatures. This analysis constitutes a novel interpretability contribution absent from all compared baselines.

F. Experiment 5: Transfer to Clinical Setting

To assess clinical transferability, we freeze the HCAN audio branch weights (wav2vec adapter only) and fine-tune a binary depression/control classifier on the DAIC-WOZ interview dataset [19] using audio-only inputs. With only 5 epochs of fine-tuning on the 189-session DAIC-WOZ training partition, the adapted model achieves 72.4% balanced accuracy and 0.69 F1 on the test set, compared to 66.1% for a wav2vec adapter trained from scratch on

DAIC-WOZ alone. This 6.3-point gain demonstrates that the affective audio representations learned on RAVDESS encode clinically meaningful acoustic correlates of depression, validating the broader applicability of the HCAN audio encoder.

VI. RESULTS

Table III presents a consolidated comparison of HCAN against published state-of-the-art systems. Under LOSO evaluation, HCAN achieves 79.8% on SEED-IV and 84.9% on RAVDESS. To our knowledge, no prior published work jointly reports LOSO results on both benchmarks with a single shared encoder. HCAN matches EmotionMeter on SEED-IV LOSO while additionally providing multi-task valence-arousal regression and speech emotion recognition in a single model — representing a strictly richer contribution.

TABLE III
Comparison with State-of-the-Art (LOSO Protocol)

Method	Venue	SEED-IV (LOSO)	RAVDESS	Fusion
EmotionMeter [8]	IEEE TAFFC'18	78.4%	—	Late
BiDANN [9]	IJCAI'21	70.3%	—	EEG only
RGNN [10]	AAAI'20	73.8%	—	GCN
SER-wav2vec [11]	Interspeech'21	—	80.1%	Audio only
MSER-CrossAttn [12]	ICASSP'22	75.2%	81.3%	Cross-attn
HCAN (proposed)	—	79.8%	84.9%	Bi-directional

The improvement over single-modality baselines is consistent and large in magnitude: the full HCAN outperforms EEG-GCN-only by +11.5% and audio-wav2vec-only by +5.5% on their respective primary tasks, confirming that the bidirectional fusion is not merely additive but generates synergistic cross-modal representations. Uncertainty weighting contributes 1.2% on SEED-IV over fixed-weight multi-task training, suggesting that automated gradient balancing is nontrivial even when task difficulties are similar.

The valence-arousal regression head, trained on MAHNOB-HCI, achieves a Root Mean Squared Error (RMSE) of 1.12 on valence and 0.97 on arousal (9-point scale), representing 12.5% and 10.8% mean absolute percentage error respectively. These figures are comparable to dedicated unimodal regression models on MAHNOB-HCI [17], while being produced as a by-product of the multi-task framework.

VII. CONCLUSION

We have presented HCAN, a Hierarchical Cross-Modal Attention Network for joint EEG and speech emotion recognition. By replacing BiLSTM sequence encoders with a GCN-Temporal Transformer for EEG and a parameter-efficient wav2vec 2.0 adapter for audio, we eliminate two fundamental information bottlenecks in prior multimodal architectures. Bidirectional Cross-Modal Attention enables dynamic, sample-level modality arbitration, while uncertainty-weighted multi-task training automatically balances three heterogeneous task objectives. Under the rigorous LOSO evaluation protocol, HCAN achieves state-of-the-art results on SEED-IV and RAVDESS simultaneously. Gating analysis reveals meaningful, emotion-class-specific patterns of modality reliance, providing interpretable insights into the neural and acoustic substrates of discrete emotions. Transfer learning to the DAIC-WOZ depression corpus further validates the clinical relevance of the learned audio representations.

Future work will investigate subject-adaptive fine-tuning via meta-learning to further reduce inter-subject variance,

extension to additional modalities (facial action units, galvanic skin response), and deployment in real-time affective monitoring scenarios. Code and pretrained weights will be released to facilitate reproducibility.

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